

On Learning How to Be with Climate and Social Breakdown

Gwen Sanderson · Tips of the Day · 5 min read

“May all beings be safe well and happy and live in harmony with the world” To feel unsafe in the context of the breakdown of our natural systems is a reasonable reaction I would say. To feel deep sadness about the destruction of habitats, extinction of species and indigenous cultures, the displacement of peoples also seems a healthy reaction. As are feelings of anger about gross inequality and social injustice. I own all of these reactions without shame but with distinct guilt, (futile, but it’s there) because I’m white, live in a temperate climate, and at the moment my basic needs are met yet the food and fuel that keeps things relatively stable here is because someone, somewhere else is suffering. Helplessness and hopelessness are not uncommon reactions either. George Monbiot, has described recent political and economic decisions as, “an ideological commitment to destroying life on earth”. (Monbiot 2022) I kidded myself a few years ago that I was doing a good job at acceptance. The systemic change needed, so deep and complex, I had no chance of properly understanding the immensity of it. Climate change would be non linear and unpredictable so resource depletion although inevitable would be difficult to manage. Hoping that climate change could be averted by measures of mitigation was delusional, I thought I was at terms with all this. There were odd specific things that triggered grief. Once grief was labelled I became acquainted with what was happening in me and gradually accepted that this is how it is. As meditators we are learning, that everything arises and passes away and so it does. I told myself that my meditation practice and a smattering of Buddhist psychology were standing me in good stead. Moreover, I had been “prepping” for a decade or so. Now, I have navigated myself to live in a more peaceful, less busy way and have opportunities for both reconnecting with nature and growing food. It is easy to kid myself that I am content and at ease with the world. As meditators we are also taught to be cautious when we think we have reached a spiritual milestone or have attained a goal, because everything changes and the self is highly delusory. In fact, I realise I have, in fact been in a fog, asleep in the context of climate collapse, for some time. The “dullness and lethargy” that Carl wrote about in July’s newsletter, resonates. It is a form of denial. The immensity of what is in front of us is not something we have a frame of reference for or have had to deal with before. Breakdown of law and order because there is a depletion of basic resources and the rise of extreme right wing factions are all quite possible. The study of collapsing societies, apparently, is an academic discipline; “Collapsology”. My fears, it seems, aren’t fantasy. In response I have been passively, ever so, ever so quietly, shutting down. We know from our practice that fear is about isolation. The thinking mind gets protective of the self. Defensiveness, ill will and hatred are driven by unidentified and un-dealt with fear. I had work to do. When a friend sent me a link to a live Deep Adaptation day event in June, I signed up. Deep Adaptation was termed by Jem Bendell in 2018 in his paper, Deep Adaptation: A

Map for Navigating Climate Tragedy. Pitched at sustainability professionals and academics, it shifts the focus from mitigating climate change by reducing impact and presents the scientific case that the likelihood is that we are too late, therefore how do we talk about what to do in that context? The map he described in 2018 is defined by Resilience; a need to develop ways to adjust and transform in light of the shocks ahead of us; Relinquishment, a letting go of the habits and dependencies we have that have led us to this place; Restoration, of some of ways of life; pre hydro-carbon, such as low tech entertainment and seasonal eating. Latterly, Bendell has added Reconciliation; coming to terms with our shared mortality. Recently the concept of a map is reframed; our situation being one of maplessness. This is unknown territory, (Bendell J, 2020). The counter response to this is that conversations about social collapse come from, “doomers and gloomers.” For many people this is a nihilistic, negative and depressing response that denudes hope and is dangerous to contemplate because it accelerates fear and poor mental health. Paradoxically, however, the paper is arguing that by engaging with climate crises and social collapse as either current or imminent, we may be better able to prepare ourselves and work out how to navigate safely, the dangerous world ahead of us. Preparing ourselves spiritually is central to this, for ethical and moral choices are at stake. My experience when I attended the Deep Adaptation event was to feel better. Alongside some thirty or so other people, I engaged deeply, openly, honestly with thoughts, feelings, and experiences about climate/ social collapse. I shared and listened to information, experience, confusions, fears, frustrations, blocks, misconceptions, concerns, sadness, gratitude, wisdom, love. I even danced and sang. Despite its heavy themes, I came home lighter, happier and confident that I have and can develop the emotional and spiritual resources necessary to be in this climate chaotic world in an engaged, moral, loving and compassionate way. The Mad Max scenarios that run through my head are just responses to fear. Thoughts of locking the door, learning how to use a gun and working out where I should build a bunker, can be combatted by connecting to other people to explore how to “be” in this place, but also just by developing more togetherness generally. We, at Satipanya, can draw on the concept of Sangha; from both the arahants for inspiration to keep us strong on this path, and from each other for support. In the Deep Adaptation event, Open Space technology allowed those present to offer and choose themes to explore and structure the day with the help of a facilitator. Twelve workshops or conversations were held. For example: “Working with our experience to develop our capacity for compassion and connection in the face of collapse”, “Talking about collapse between generations” “Adjusting to redundant technologies of green agendas: should I buy a solar panel?” “Local government and politics; How to be with the Deep Adaptation agenda?” “Keeping our hearts open” “Humour and collapse” Some people offered experiences; “Dances for Universal Peace” and “Matriculture for co-liberation” The mix of intellectual, spiritual, experiential, discursive opportunities and informal spaces for conversation were all of equal value. Whatever I fear is ahead of us, is a part of my now, the present moment. Shutting down, leads to introversion, isolation, separation, and being closed off. Sometimes, it takes extroversion, verbal expression, to become aware of pain, and negative mind states. Openness allows connection, the hold that fear can have dissipates, feelings of joy and love can emerge and compassion can be developed. Constant attention to the very initial teachings of the Buddha is needed... Dhamma is absolutely, a practice.

Acceptance is not the same as complacency. To support myself further I have recently joined a group called “Deep Relating”. Described as “a ‘relational meditation’ (in a collapse aware community), a practice that allows us to become aware of our sensations, emotions, thoughts and intuitions as they arise in our communication with one another”, (similar to what I understand Insight Dialogue is). Adaptation is now main stream for policy makers at the level of United Nations down to local authorities and individual institutions. There is a broader acceptance that we need to be able to adjust. As we cultivate compassion when we are practicing Metta, maybe as a community the time has come to ask the question how are we to open up to the challenging experiences that climate and possible future social breakdown procure? Noting our experience and being present with it, is what Sayadaw Mahasi taught. I see engaging with the Deep Adaptation agenda, as an extension of just that. “May all beings be safe well and happy and live in harmony with the world”! Bendell J. (2020) ‘A Map for Navigating Climate Tragedy’ in Bendell J and Read R (ed) Deep Adaptation Navigating the Realities of Climate Chaos: Polity Monbiot G (2022) ‘Willing the end’ available at <https://www.monbiot.com/2022/07/14/willing-the-end> Sources for further exploration: <https://guidance.deepadaptation.info/method/deep-relating/> <https://www.deepadaptation.info/> <https://www.buddhistinquiry.org/course/turning-towards-the-climate-emergency-together/> <https://postdoo.com/> <https://oneearthsangha.org>

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